ABROAD SPECTRUM

How long it took for countries to see a fall in Omicron cases

- Omicron detected on
- Fastest doubling time
- Highest daily new cases
- Cases began to fall after

UK	US	South Africa
Nov. 27, 2021	Dec. 2, 2021	Nov. 24, 2021
2 days	2 days	3.2 days
218,705 (four times UK peak during Delta)	900,047 (double the US peak during Delta)	37,875 (almost double that of the Delta wave peak)
Jan 4., 2022	Jan. 7, 2022	Dec. 16, 2021



ANI

tions spread from the south and west to the rest of the country, Omicron has had a near-simultaneous impact in cities in north and east India too. As on January 9, five states—Maharashtra, West Bengal, Delhi, Tamil Nadu and Karnataka—were reporting the maximum number of cases, with West Bengal recording the highest weekly positivity rate of 29.91 per cent and Maharashtra and Delhi averaging 17 per cent each. Cases in Bihar, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Haryana, Punjab, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Odisha have begun to accelerate too. So rapid has been its spread that while only 78 districts reported a positivity rate above the danger mark of 5 per cent on January 4, by January 11, 300 districts across the country were reporting higher positivity rates. Among cities, Delhi and Mumbai are leading in terms of number of cases followed by Bengaluru, Pune, Chennai, and Kolkata. What's worrying is that given its infectivity and penchant for breaching the defences of even the vaccinated, Omicron's is, as Dr Paul puts it, "a Qutub Minar kind of rise and not a gentle rising slope. We are hoping Omicron's fall will be as steep."

IS OMICRON MILDER COMPARED TO DELTA?

According to a CDC study, the four most common symptoms of Omicron are a cold, fatigue, nasal congestion and a runny nose. An ongoing study by King's College London has also recorded nausea, loss of appetite and night sweats as symptoms. Mercifully, various studies are now confirming that Omicron results in milder illness than Delta. According to a study led by researchers at South Africa's National Institute for Communicable Diseases, individuals infected with Omicron between October and early December 2021 had 80 per cent lesser risk of hospitalisation. The study, which is yet to be peer-reviewed, also noted a 30 per cent reduction in risk of severe complications. The percentage of risk varies across countries. The UK Health Security Agency (UKHSA) says the risk of Omicron resulting in severe disease is approximately half that of Delta, and that of hospital admission approximately a third compared to Delta. CDC data shows that adults are 29 per cent less likely to be hospitalised. However, while Omicron symptoms may appear milder as compared to Delta, WHO director-general Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus warns, "Omicron is not the common cold."

In India, experts attribute the public's lack of caution towards Omicron to its relative mildness. Indeed, Omicron symptoms may not be as severe as the ones Delta triggers, but it can still cause sufficient damage on its own to keep a person bedridden for over a week. "Covid-induced fever and cold can really drain your energy," says Dr Aditya S Chowti, senior internal medicine consultant at Fortis Hospitals, Cunningham Road, Bengaluru. "Many patients also complain of severe body and joint ache. Should you test positive, it is important to take a lot of rest and eat nutritious food to give your body the vitamins, minerals and calories it needs to cope with the illness." Shreya Bakshi, a 34-year-old business administration student in Gurugram, learnt her lesson the hard way. "I was diagnosed with Covid recently after